

Final Round: Lisbon HQ HR Interview

The business already said yes. This round is yours to lose — be consistent, warm, and low-risk.

1 · What this round actually is

- The Head of Corporate Finance approved you on substance. **HR's job is to confirm, not re-test.** They screen for risk, fit and alignment — then close the admin (package, notice, start date).
- Expect **100% English**, most likely a **video call** from Lisbon, typically 30–45 minutes, softer pace than the business round.
- Winning behaviour: **likeable and safe**, not dazzling. The research bomb already landed in round one — with HR, deploy deep analysis **only if asked**.

2 · The five things HR is screening for

Screen	What it looks like	Your counter
1. Retention risk	The RM→Analyst move is a flag. They'll probe it in disguises: "are you sure?", "what if the pay disappoints?", "where in 5 years?"	Same calm answer every time: platform decision, eyes open, choosing to build (§3 below)
2. Consistency	They have notes from round one. Contradictions on motivation, salary, timeline or deal claims are red flags	Tell the same story — same numbers, same reasons, same tone
3. Compensation alignment	The Analyst band may sit below your current RM package. Their fear: you accept, then resent, then leave	The "eyes open" salary script (§3) — realistic, not desperate, not greedy
4. Culture & cross-border fit	European HQ, global footprint. Can you work with Lisbon, across time zones, in English?	Warmth, small talk, the Macau-Portugal connection (§5), group-level knowledge (§3)
5. Clean background	Banks verify everything: dates, degree, claims, restrictions from BOC	Only verifiable claims; honest answer on confidentiality / notice (§3)

3 · Likely questions — model answers

Q1. Walk me through your career and why this move. (90-second HR version — less technical than round one)

SAY THIS

"I've spent just over five years at Bank of China, Macau — first two years as a product manager in digital finance, then three as a Relationship Manager in corporate banking, where I manage about 8 billion HKD in loans and 7 billion in deposits, and have executed more than 2 billion US dollars of transactions.

I'm making this move because Haitong offers something my current bank can't: a European-regulated platform connected to China's largest securities group, right at the start of building its corporate banking business in Macau. I want to help build that, and grow with it."

Q2. You're moving from RM to Analyst — are you sure? What if it disappoints? (THE retention probe — expect it more than once, in different clothes)

SAY THIS

"It's a fair question, and I didn't make this decision casually. Three things give me confidence. First, I'm moving toward the work I want — structured finance and capital markets, which my current role can't offer. Second, I did my homework on exactly what stage the branch's business is at, so I'm joining with realistic expectations, not rosy ones. And third, the title matters less to me than the trajectory: an Analyst on a growing platform gets to build something; a comfortable RM on a mature platform mostly maintains it. I'm choosing to build."

Q3. The branch had a difficult 2025 — doesn't that worry you? (only if THEY raise it)

SAY THIS

"I know — I read the branch's financial disclosures before my first interview. 2025 was hard because fee income depends on mainland offshore bond issuance, and that market pulled back. Honestly, that's part of why this role makes sense: the bank is building corporate banking precisely to add stable, recurring income next to the investment banking franchise. I'd rather join a platform at the start of that build than after it's finished."

Q4. What are your salary expectations? (the real negotiation happens here)

SAY THIS

"I've done my homework, and I understand an Analyst band may be structured differently from my current RM package. I'm making a platform decision with my eyes open. What matters to me is a fair number within your structure and room to grow with performance. My current total compensation is [X] — I'm not asking you to match it blindly; I'm asking for the strongest number the band allows, and I trust performance will close the gap. May I ask the range you have in mind for this role?"

Discipline: decide your floor before the call and never state it. Anchor on **total comp** (base + bonus + benefits), not base alone. Never badmouth BOC's pay. If they push "give me a number first": give a range whose bottom is your floor + ~10%.

Q5. Notice period and start date?

SAY THIS

"My contract requires [X days / one month] notice. I can start on [date], and I'll manage a clean, professional handover — that's how I'd want to be treated in reverse."

Q6. Are you bound by any restrictions from your current employer?

SAY THIS

"I'm bound by standard confidentiality obligations, which I take seriously — I won't bring any client data or confidential material with me. To my knowledge there is no non-compete that would prevent me from taking this role. What I bring is my skills, my training, and my understanding of the market."

Q7. Tell me about a conflict with a colleague and how you handled it. (classic HR behavioral — adapt to a real case)

SAY THIS

"On one syndicated deal, a senior coverage colleague wanted to soften the risk section of my credit paper to speed up approval — I had flagged a customer-concentration issue. I didn't argue in the meeting. Afterwards, I prepared a one-page analysis showing how similar exposures had behaved, and proposed keeping the flag but adding mitigants — a covenant and enhanced monitoring — so the deal could still proceed. He agreed, credit approved it with the mitigants, and the deal closed. What I learned is that disagreement handled with data and respect usually strengthens both the deal and the relationship."

Q8. Tell me about a mistake you made. (pick a real, small, fixed one — never claim perfection, never pick a catastrophe)

SAY THIS

"Early in my product manager days, I published a monthly analytics report with a data error — I had trusted an upstream extract without validating it, and a stakeholder caught it. I corrected it the same day, apologised directly, and then built a validation checklist that became standard for our team — we never had a repeat. It taught me that speed without verification is a false economy, which is exactly the mindset credit work needs."

Q9. What do you know about Haitong Bank? (the GROUP version — a Lisbon HR manager will notice you know the European side)

SAY THIS

"Haitong Bank is an EU-regulated investment bank headquartered in Lisbon — originally the investment banking arm of Banco Espírito Santo, acquired by Haitong in 2015 — with offices across Iberia, the UK, Poland, Brazil, and Macau. Today it's part of Guotai Haitong, China's largest securities group. What makes it unique is the bridge: European licensing and standards combined with Chinese deal flow. The Macau branch is the Asia-Pacific gateway of that bridge — and that's the part I want to help build."

4 · Questions to ask HR (different from business questions)

- "What does onboarding look like for Macau hires — and how is the probation period structured?"
- "How do Macau colleagues typically collaborate with the Lisbon teams — are there training programmes or visit opportunities with headquarters?" (signals long-term commitment)
- "What are the next steps and timeline from here?"

5 · Rapport: the Macau-Portugal card

- You are a Macau native talking to Lisbon. The **400-year Macau-Portugal connection** is the most natural rapport builder available: the architecture, the food, the street names, bilingual signage. One warm sentence in small talk ("working for a Lisbon-headquartered bank feels natural for someone from Macau — the connection is everywhere in my city") lands beautifully. Genuine, not flattery.
- European HR style: a little small talk first, softer pace, politeness. Mirror it. Smile. Don't rush to prove things.

6 · Video call logistics (if remote from Lisbon)

- [] Time zone: Lisbon is **7 hours behind** Macau in summer (10:00 Lisbon = 17:00 Macau) — double-check the invite
- [] Test camera/mic/link the day before · join 3–5 min early · quiet room, clean background, camera at eye level
- [] Full business dress even on video · phone silent · water ready
- [] Have the cram card and your CV printed beside you — glanceable, not readable-from

7 · Consistency checklist (match round one exactly)

- [] Same motivation story (platform, not title)
- [] Same salary posture (if comp came up in round one, repeat it)
- [] Same notice period and start date
- [] Same deal facts if Dali comes up (60-second non-technical version: "led the financing analysis for the take-private of a HK-listed food group — about HK\$7.6 billion — the deal I'm proudest of")
- [] Everything you claim must survive a background check

8 · After the call

- Send a short thank-you email the same day: 3–4 sentences, reaffirm enthusiasm, no new arguments.
- If they gave a timeline, wait it out + 2 business days before following up.

Mindset: the hard gate is behind you. HR needs to feel three things when the call ends: **he's staying, he's easy to work with, he'll represent us well.** Calm, warm, consistent.